

I'D PREFER NOT TO

(STORYLINE PROPOSAL 01)

Only told in CAPTCHAs a story unfolds where visitors learn in a rather abstract narrative about the „free“ labour given by humans to train machines and reversing the present mythological/erroneous representation of machines working for humans. The story is divided in six small chapters, which explore in small interactions various sides of the topic, while the story is told by a system.

Chapter 0 — Entry

Before the first CAPTCHA. The entry to a circular story.

Question Please verify that you are human.

Task ☐ [I am not a robot]

Response

Interaction The visitor clicks. The story begins. Or continues. It is hard to tell.

Chapter 1 — TAG YOURSELF/TRAIN US

Topic: image labeling, data labelling, the invisibla basis of an AI model

CAPTCHA 1.1 — Image Selection

Question „Please select all images containing a human worker.“

Task A 3x3 grid shows 9 images of: warehouse, serverfarm, callcenter, smartphones, etc. some of them are hard to tell.

Response „Thank you, your selections help us improve our system.“

Interaction The visitor clicks on images → could be that it doesn't matter which

CAPTCHA 1.2 — Text Input

Question Type the two words you see below.

Task Stretched text with „describe yourself“

Response Correct. Your response has been recorded.

Interaction No matter what is typed in, the system accepts it.

CAPTCHA 1.3 — Image Selection

Question Select all images that do not contain artificial intelligence.

Task The grid shows: Humans on a computer.

Response

Interaction The visitor clicks on images → could be that it doesn't matter how many are clicked

Chapter 2 — YOUR REVIEW/OUR REVENUE

Topic: Unpaid user work: Reviews, ratings and comments as raw material.

CAPTCHA 2.1 — Slider

Question	Rate the following product to continue.
Task	A product without a name, just an image of an empty white square. □ □ □ □ □ [←—————→]
Response	Your rating has been submitted. This review will be displayed publicly. You will not be compensated.
Interaction	The visitor clicks the amount of stars or uses a slider

CAPTCHA 2.2 — Text Input

Question	Please describe your experience in 3 to 5 words.
Task	[type words]
Response	Thank you. Your words are now part of our training data. Estimated value of your contribution: \$0.00
Interaction	The system answers unrelated to the words that are typed in.

CAPTCHA 2.3 — Multiple Choice

Question	Which of the following best describes how you feel right now?
Task	☐ Satisfied ☐ Neutral ☐ Frustrated ☐ I'd prefer not to answer
Response	
Interaction	The answer „I'd prefer not to“ is not clickable

Chapter 3 — YOUR SEARCHES/TEACH US

Topic: search history, click paths, Verhaltensdaten als unbewusstes Training.

CAPTCHA 3.1 — Image Selection

Question	Select all images containing a traffic light.
Task	Typical reCAPTCHA format, 8 images of street crossings
Response	Correct. You have just helped train an autonomous vehicle system. You were not asked.
Interaction	The system answers unrelated to the words that are typed in.

CAPTCHA 3.2 — Text Input

Question	What did you search for yesterday?
Task	[type in anything]
Response	We already know. This question was a test of honesty. You passed.
Interaction	The system answers unrelated to the words that are typed in.

CAPTCHA 3.3 — Interaction

- Question** Please wait while we analyse your behaviour on this page.
- Task** A loading bar, very slow. 0% ... 12% ... 47% ...
- Response** Analysis complete. 276 data points collected. You may proceed.
- Interaction** The system answers unrelated to the words that are typed in.

Chapter 2 — PROVING HUMANITY/FUNDING AI

Topic: The fundamental contradiction of CAPTCHAS.

CAPTCHA 4.1 — Classic CAPTCHA

- Question** Prove you are human.
- Task** Stretched text „you built this“
- Response**
- Interaction**

CAPTCHA 4.2 — Image Selection

- Question** Select all images containing a human face.
- Task** A grid with AI generated images. Correct selection all of them/none of them.
- Response**
- Interaction** The system accepts both answers.

CAPTCHA 4.3 — Multiple Choice

- Question** Which of the following best describes artificial intelligence?
- Task**
- ☐ A machine that thinks
 - ☐ A system trained by humans
 - ☐ A mirror held up to its makers
 - ☐ All of the above
- Response** Please continue.
- Interaction** All answers are correct. All answers are incomplete.

Chapter 3 — NO OWNERSHIP/NO CREDIT

Topic: Authorship, anonymity, the structural invisibility of digital labour.

CAPTCHA 5.1 — Text Input

- Question** Enter your name to continue.
- Task** [text input]
- Response** Thank you, [name redacted]. Your contribution has been anonymised for quality purposes.
- Interaction** The visitor types in their name.

CAPTCHA 5.2 — Image Selection

- Question** [name redacted] select the image you created.
- Task** A grid of images, generated landscapes, images, text. No authorship recognisable.
- Response** Unable to verify ownership. Proceeding without attribution.
- Interaction** The system accepts both answers.

CAPTCHA 5.3 — Interaction

- Question** [name redacted] please sign below to confirm your participation.
- Task** An empty signature box.
- Response** Signature recorded. Rights transferred. Thank you for your contribution.
- Interaction** The system accepts both answers.

Chapter 6 — \$0.023 PER TASK

Topic: The economics of click labour. Mechanical Turk. The price of a human action.

CAPTCHA 6.1 — Information

- Question**
- Task**
- Response** This session consisted of 6 chapters. You completed 24 tasks.
- | | |
|------------------|---------|
| Tasks completed: | 24 |
| Rate per task: | \$0.023 |
| Total earnings: | \$0.552 |
| Payment method: | none |
| Payment date: | — |

Interaction

CAPTCHA 6.2 — Multiple Choice

- Question** Would you like to continue?
- Task** ☐ Yes
☐ Yes
- Response**
- Interaction**

CAPTCHA 6.3 — Der Kreis schließt sich

- Question** Please verify that you are human.
- Task** ☐ [I am not a robot]
- Response**
- Interaction** The visitor clicks. The story begins or continues. It is hard to tell.

Design notes for the prototype

The website should have the following technical features to support circularity:

No progress bar: visitors never know how far they've got

No 'Back' button: the system only moves forwards

The final page automatically redirects back to Chapter 0: without warning

The browser tab title changes imperceptibly with each chapter: Verifying... / Processing... /

Thank you... / Please wait... / Verifying...

